

71 Mephibosheth

Jonathan's lame son, who was brought from hiding to eat at the king's table.

Mephibosheth was the son of Jonathan and grandson of King Saul. He was five when his father and grandfather died on Mount Gilboa. His nurse fled with him in panic, he fell, and he was lame in both feet for life. He grew up in hiding, with every reason to fear David, since a new king often wiped out the old king's family. Instead, David sought someone from Saul's house to show kindness to "for Jonathan's sake." He gave Mephibosheth back his land and a place at the royal table: a clear picture of grace, given because of a promise.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew <i>Mefiboshet</i> ; also Merib-baal (1 Chronicles 8:34)
Family	Son of Jonathan; grandson of Saul; father of Micha
Disability	Lame in both feet from a fall at age five (2 Samuel 4:4)
When	Born c. 1015 BC; lived through David's reign
Key places	Lo-debar, Jerusalem
Key people	David, Jonathan, Ziba, Machir son of Ammiel
Not the same as	Saul's son by Rizpah (2 Samuel 21:8)
New Testament	Not named

"Fear not: for I will surely shew thee kindness for Jonathan thy father's sake ... and thou shalt eat bread at my table continually."

2 Samuel 9:7, KJV

The life of Mephibosheth

Dates are approximate (BC). He was five when Saul and Jonathan died (c. 1010 BC), so he was born c. 1015 BC. Later events cannot be dated closely.

c. 1010 BC Age 5	● Lamed in the escape Word comes from Jezreel that Saul and Jonathan are dead. His nurse picks him up and flees, but in her haste he falls and becomes lame. <i>2 Samuel 4:4</i>
Growing up	● Hidden in Lo-debar He lives in the house of Machir son of Ammiel, at Lo-debar east of the Jordan. By the time David finds him, he has a young son named Micha. <i>2 Samuel 9:4, 12</i>
David's reign	● Brought to the king David asks whether anyone is left of Saul's house. Saul's servant Ziba names Mephibosheth. David restores Saul's land to him and seats him at the king's table "as one of the king's sons." <i>2 Samuel 9:1-13</i>
Absalom's revolt	● Accused by Ziba As David flees Jerusalem, Ziba meets him with supplies and claims that Mephibosheth has stayed behind, hoping to regain Saul's kingdom. David gives Ziba all that was Mephibosheth's. <i>2 Samuel 16:1-4</i>
The king's return	● Meets David Mephibosheth comes out unwashed, with feet undressed and beard untrimmed, as he has been since David left. He says Ziba deceived him. David divides the land between them. <i>2 Samuel 19:24-30</i>
The famine years	● Spared A three-year famine is traced to Saul's wrong against the Gibeonites. When they demand seven of Saul's descendants, David spares Mephibosheth because of his oath to Jonathan. <i>2 Samuel 21:1-9</i>

Key activities

Ziba and Mephibosheth gave David opposite stories (2 Samuel 16:1–4; 19:24–30). Many readers believe Mephibosheth, since his long mourning shows loyalty. Others think Ziba may have been telling the truth. David himself seemed unsure and divided the land, and Scripture does not settle it.

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- 1 Survived a disaster as a child.** He lived through his family's fall, but it left him lame. *2 Samuel 4:4*
 - 2 Came when the king called.** He came before David, fell on his face and said, "Behold thy servant!" *2 Samuel 9:6*
 - 3 Saw himself as unworthy.** "What is thy servant, that thou shouldest look upon such a dead dog as I am?" *2 Samuel 9:8*
 - 4 Ate at the king's table.** He lived in Jerusalem and ate "continually at the king's table." *2 Samuel 9:11–13*
 - 5 Mourned while the king was away.** He did not care for his feet, trim his beard or wash his clothes until David returned in peace. *2 Samuel 19:24*
 - 6 Cared more for the king than the land.** "Yea, let him take all, forasmuch as my lord the king is come again in peace unto his own house." *2 Samuel 19:30*
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Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Mephibosheth.

Old Testament

2 Samuel 4:4	How he became lame
2 Samuel 9:1-13	David's kindness to him
2 Samuel 16:1-4; 19:24-30	Ziba's accusation and Mephibosheth's answer
2 Samuel 21:7	Spared because of "the LORD's oath" with Jonathan
1 Chronicles 8:34; 9:40	As Merib-baal, listed with son Micah
Echo: 1 Samuel 20:14-17	Jonathan asks kindness for his house for ever
Echo: Psalm 23:5	"Thou preparest a table before me"

New Testament

Echo: Luke 14:21	The maimed and the halt invited to the banquet
Echo: Ephesians 2:8	Saved by grace, the gift of God

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did David give Mephibosheth, and why (2 Samuel 9:1, 7)?
2. *Understand:* Mephibosheth called himself a "dead dog." How does his view of himself make David's kindness stand out?
3. *Apply:* David kept a promise to a friend long after the friend was gone. Is there a promise you have made that still needs keeping?
4. *Apply:* Who is "hidden in Lo-debar" around you, overlooked or afraid, and how could you welcome them to your table?